Briefing

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Understanding the war in Sudan

The human cost of geopolitics

Eric Pichon, map and graph by Lucille Killmayer, Members' Research Service

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Summary

The Sudanese are caught in a devastating civil war, driven by deep political fragmentation, with far-reaching humanitarian and human rights consequences. While President Al-Bashir's ousting in 2019 had raised hopes for a democratic transition, deep divisions between the regular Sudanese Armed Forces (SAF) and the paramilitary Rapid Support Forces (RSF) derailed power-sharing attempts. This has triggered violent conflict across the country since April 2023, exacerbating hostilities between communities and resulting in competing administrations, further weakening prospects for reconciliation.

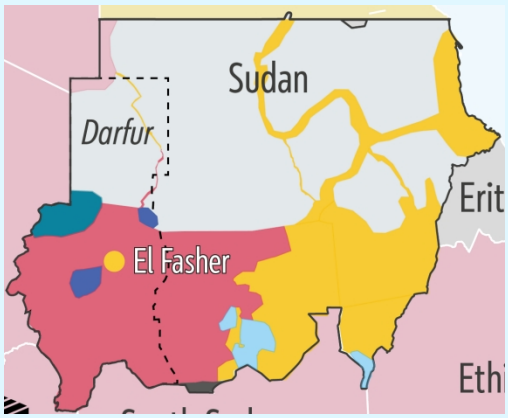
Many thousands of civilians have been killed in the conflict, while abuses such as sexual violence and forced recruitment of children to armed groups are widespread. Natural disasters compound the impact of violence, leaving the majority of Sudan's population in urgent need of assistance. International humanitarian law is routinely violated, by restrictions on humanitarian access, attacks on aid workers, destruction of health facilities, and the weaponisation of hunger. The conflict has unleashed massive displacement, with millions forced to flee their homes both within Sudan and across borders, overwhelming neighbouring states and threatening to further destabilise the Horn of Africa.

Regional and international players back rival factions according to complex geostrategic interests in this resource-rich country on the Red Sea. These external alliances fuel the conflict, notably contributing to the proliferation of arms, and make it particularly difficult to achieve consensus or pursue a sustainable solution at the United Nations level. Several competing peacemaking initiatives have been launched with little progress, although a roadmap agreed on 12 September 2025 has raised cautious optimism among international mediators.

The European Union (EU) has intensified its humanitarian response and plays a leading role in coordinating peace initiatives. The European Parliament has consistently urged the EU and other stakeholders to maintain pressure on all parties to cease hostilities and to ensure that Sudanese civil society is genuinely included in dialogue towards a sustainable solution.

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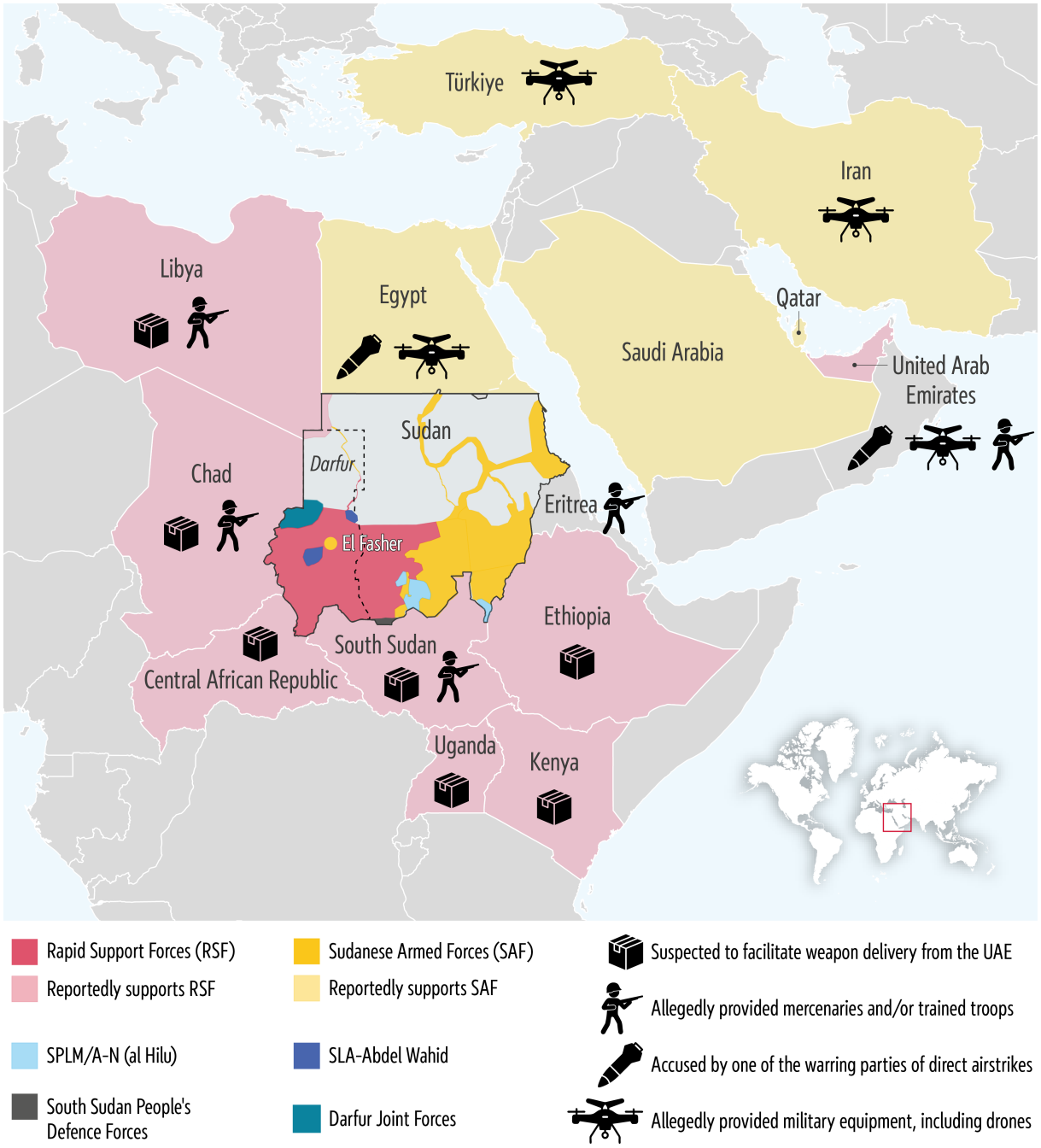
A torn country

After President Al-Bashir was deposed by a coup d'état in April 2019, Sudan attempted a transition to democracy. A transitional government led by a civilian Prime Minister, Abdalla Hamdok, with a Sovereign Council, headed by Lieutenant General Abdel-Fattah Al-Burhan and General Muhammad Hamdan 'Hemedti' Dagolo, sharing power. **Al-Burhan** was a former commander of the regular army, the **Sudanese Armed Forces** (SAF) in Central Darfur State and in Yemen, and **Hemedti** was chief of the **Rapid Support Forces** (RSF) – a paramilitary group in control of the mining sector (mainly gold in Darfur). Previously two of Al-Bashir's regime pillars, the SAF and the RSF have turned against him.

The SAF and RSF overthrew the civilian government in October 2021, stalling the transition process. Despite the resumption of talks between political and military leaders, commitments to adopt a new constitution and to transfer the power to a civilian administration in April 2023 were never met, as rivalry between Al-Burhan and Hemedti escalated. One of the main disputes between the two military factions was the integration of the RSF into the national armed forces: Al-Burhan aimed to unite the two military forces within two years, Hemedti wanted a ten-year delay.

On 15 April 2023, fighting erupted in Khartoum between the SAF and the RSF, quickly spreading across the country.[1] The conflict has since fragmented Sudan around shifting frontlines mainly opposing the SAF and the RSF, building on inter-community grievances between Arabic-speaking Muslims (70 % of Sudan's population), Furs, Masalit, Zaghawa, and other groups. Other armed groups are also involved in the fighting: In Darfur, the Justice and Equality Movement (JEM), the Sudan Liberation Army Minni Minawi (SLA/MM) and Malik Agar's faction of the Sudan People's Liberation Movement (SPLM-N Malik Agar) have aligned with SAF, while SLA Abdul Wahid (SLA/AW) is allied with RSF, notably for the gold trade. SPLM-N al-Hilu defends territories in the Blue Nile and South Kordofan against SAF, and the Third Front-Tamazuj is present near Chad and the Central African Republic. The South Sudan People's Defence Forces (SSPDF) controls part of the disputed territory of Abyei (see map, Figure 1).

Figure 1 - Sudan: areas controlled by the SAF, the RSF and other groups; regional countries' support



Source: EPRS; icons © xoawPic, creatix, DesiArt/Adobe Stock; data source: for control areas: courtesy of Thomas van Linge, 9 October 2025; for external support: UN, Africa Confidential, ECFR, ISPI, WI Fikra Forum, and other sources, 2025. During the last week of October 2025, the RSF seized El Fasher after a siege of over 500 days.

Civil society organisations, which played a key role in Al-Bashir's ousting, have been sidelined and split across different positions. The **Somoud Coalition**, led by former Prime Minister Abdalla Hamdok, calls for dialogue between the parties and reportedly has regular contact with the United Nations (UN) and African Union (AU). While the SAF is supported by islamist organisations, Somoud is rather in line with the RSF's federalist and secular stance, however it stands against the breach of Sudan's unity between the main two factions.

By contrast, on 26 July 2025, the **Sudan Founding Alliance** ('Tasis'), a coalition of armed and political groups allied to the RSF, announced the creation of **a parallel government** in RSF-controlled areas, headquartered in Nyala, the capital of South Darfur state, with Mohamed Hassan al-Ta'ayshi – a former

member of the 2019-2021 transitional council – as prime minister. This move was swiftly rejected by the AU's Peace and Security Council, the Arab League and the UN Security Council; the EU had already condemned RSF plans for a parallel administration in March 2025.

The **internationally recognised government** led by Al-Burhan has relocated from Khartoum to Port Sudan. A civilian Prime Minister, Kamal Idris, was appointed in May 2025. However, February 2025 constitutional amendments have postponed the transition to a civilian government to 2028 and increased the power of the army in the government.

The two parallel administrations are entrenching Sudan's de facto partition, with both the SAF and RSF impeding services and supplies from reaching areas outside their control.

Human rights and humanitarian situation

The civil war has resulted in a severe and escalating humanitarian and human rights crisis.

Killings of civilian and human rights abuses

The death toll is difficult to estimate, it could range from around 30 000 fatalities **up to 150 000 deaths** since April 2023, directly due to the fighting and, more importantly, to its impact (starvation and disease).

The UN Human Rights Council's (HRC) Fact-Finding Mission on Sudan has documented severe violations of international human rights and humanitarian law by both the RSF and SAF. Attacks on and killings of civilians and the destruction of their homes and means of livelihood are systematic. The Mission describes large-scale RSF attacks, particularly targeting the Masalit and other non-Arab populations in Darfur. Some analysts fear this could amount to ethnic cleansing or even genocide.

The UN describes sexual violence widespread' and mostly attributed to the RSF and their allies. Women and girls have been abducted and submitted to sexual slavery. Grave violations against children include rape and recruitment as child soldiers. Civil society representatives, human rights defenders and journalists are threatened, attacked, and killed.

Displacements and humanitarian needs

Some 15 million people have been forcibly displaced: 11.5 million (IDPs: internally displaced persons) within Sudan and 3.5 million across borders. This is the world's largest displacement crisis, impacting on already unstable areas in Chad, Ethiopia, and South Sudan.

A further 30 million Sudanese (64 % of the population), including 16 million children, are in urgent need of humanitarian assistance. Around 25 million face acute food insecurity, with famine risks in several areas. Attacks on health facilities have left three quarters of them inoperable, severely hampering the response to cholera and other outbreaks. Humanitarian access is severely constrained and food aid convoys are attacked by both the SAF and RSF. The weaponisation of hunger is evident in **El Fasher**, the capital of North Darfur (a remaining SAF stronghold until its complete seizure by the RSF in the last week of October), where the RSF blocks supplies, imposes huge fees on those wanting to flee, and targets civilians on escape routes.

In addition, natural disasters such as landslides and floods exacerbate displacement and destruction, further complicating humanitarian operations.

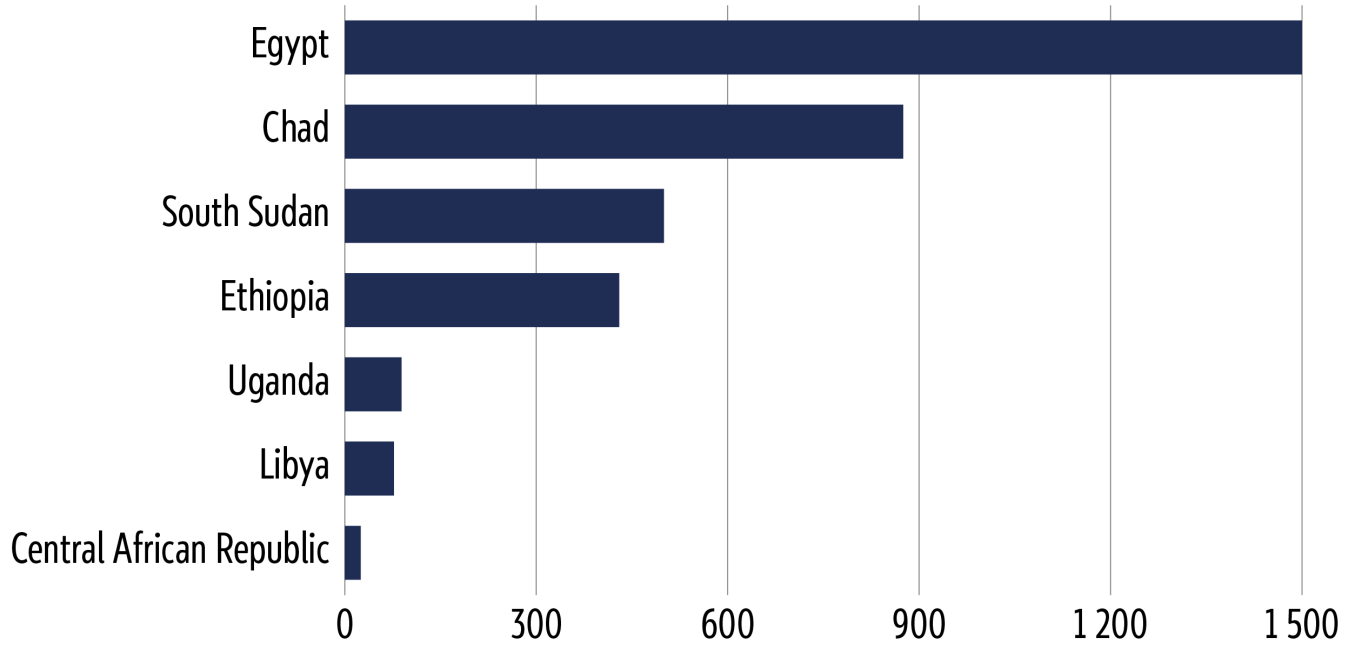
In this context, cuts in international funding, in particular by the United States, already have catastrophic impact.

International implications

Humanitarian spillover

Over 3.5 million people have fled to neighbouring countries (see Figure 2), not including refugees in Sudan forced to return to their country of origin. This puts an additional strain on countries already grappling with internal crises and displacements.

Figure 2 - Increase in Sudanese refugees in neighbouring countries since April 2023 - in thousands



Data source: refugees and asylum seekers registered by the UN Refugee Agency (UNHCR) since the outbreak of the conflict in April 2023, July 2025 (Egypt, Ethiopia, Libya, Central African Republic) and August 2025 (Chad, South Sudan (estimates), Uganda).

Foreign support

Both sides have been trying to strengthen alliances with neighbouring countries and global players. Ethnic or religious proximity partly explains alignments – the SAF are perceived to have Islamist leanings, while the RSF are seen as more secular, closer to neglected minorities and regions. More importantly, as the country is strategically positioned between Sub-Saharan Africa and the Arab world, broader geopolitical considerations play a significant role, including vying for control of the Red Sea strategic waterways and access to gold and mineral resources. As a result, the country is awash with smuggled weapons, including from European factories, despite the UN embargo in Darfur.

Neighbouring and Horn of Africa countries

Egypt has sided with the SAF and the official government, which it considers an ally for regional stability, and against the Grand Ethiopian Renaissance Dam on the River Nile. This support translates into military provisions and alleged airstrikes against the RSF, as well as diplomatic backing.

After aligning with the SAF, **Eritrea** has adopted a neutral stance. However, it is reportedly sponsoring several armed groups in Eastern Sudan, mostly but not exclusively linked to SAF. The UN suspects **Chad**, **Libya** (non-internationally recognised Libyan National Army), the **Central African Republic** and **South Sudan** of facilitating weapons delivery from the United Arab Emirates (UAE) to the RSF; **Kenya** ,

Ethiopia and **Uganda** are also suspected. Armed groups from these countries are also accused of training or providing recruits, or fighting alongside RSF troops in border areas. Ethiopia reportedly backs the RSF, which had supported the Ethiopian regime in its combat against the Tigray People's Liberation Front (TPLF). Kenya has been criticised by the SAF for hosting RSF political meetings.

Gulf countries and regional powers

Although Emirati leaders deny, many observers consider the **United Arab Emirates** (UAE) the main provider of arms, mercenaries and finance to the RSF, which allegedly secures access to gold mines and agricultural resources for the UAE. The SAF even accused the UAE of direct drone attacks on Port Sudan. However, as the SAF have retaken Khartoum, the UAE is said to have attempted to re-engage with the Sudanese authorities.

Saudi Arabia (and to a lesser extent, Qatar) has engaged in mediation efforts, however it is considered to lean towards the SAF, partly dictated by its regional competition with the UAE. It has reportedly promised to fund Khartoum's reconstruction.

Türkiye and **Iran** support the SAF, notably by supplying drones, to gain influence over key Red Sea shipping lanes, a way for the latter to offset the impact of Western sanctions.

Main international players

Russia officially supports the SAF-led regime, which has approved the establishment of a Russian military base in Port Sudan. However, Russia-sponsored paramilitary forces are said to control Sudanese gold mines in the areas controlled by the RSF; Ukrainian forces reportedly fought alongside the SAF against these mercenaries and the RSF, allegedly to disrupt the funding of Russia's war in Ukraine by Sudanese gold, among other reasons.

China aims to secure long-term access to resources, notably South Sudanese oil transiting through Port Sudan, where it has kept a diplomatic presence, engaging with the SAF. At the same time, the UAE supplies Chinese drones and other military goods to the RSF.

The **United States** (US) imposed targeted sanctions on leaders of both the SAF and RSF, including Al-Durhan and Hemedti. It has engaged in peace talks (see below), however the division between its Gulf allies allegedly diminishes both its leverage and that of Western countries.

Diplomatic efforts by international and regional players

Investigations and sanctions

The **International Criminal Court** (ICC) is investigating the ongoing conflict since July 2023. Its Deputy Prosecutor reported in July 2025 that the ICC has 'reasonable grounds' to believe that war crimes and crimes against humanity are being committed in Darfur. The SAF-led government accused the UAE of being complicit of genocide in the region, but the **International Court of Justice** (ICJ) dismissed the case, as the UAE does not recognise the ICJ's jurisdiction over disputes related to the Genocide Convention.

UN Security Council (UNSC) Resolution 2791 (2025) has extended the sanctions (assets freezes, travel bans), and an arms embargo already in place regarding the situation in Darfur, until September 2026. However, this resolution does not include clear reference to the surge in conflict-related sexual violence and the role of mercenaries across Sudan since April 2023. This is notably due to Russia's opposition. **Russia** abstained on most of the UNSC resolutions on Sudan since the outbreak of the conflict – notably Resolution 2736 (2024) demanding that the RSF halt the siege of El Fasher (which

has not yet happened) – and even vetoed a resolution on protecting civilians, which it claimed undermined Sudan's sovereignty.

An independent international **Fact-Finding Mission** for Sudan was established in October 2023 by the UN Human Rights Council, with a mandate extended until October 2026. This Mission's reports highlight severe human rights violations committed by all parties (see above). The Mission calls for credible accountability mechanisms for perpetrators, and stricter enforcement of the arms embargo.

The European Union (EU, see below) and the **US** imposed sanctions on both the RSF and SAF. The US Biden administration even 'concluded that members of the RSF and allied militias have committed genocide in Sudan'.

Difficult mediation

Mediation attempts have been undermined by SAF and RSF ideological differences and their will to consolidate their military positions before negotiating. The spillover of geopolitical rivalries, including at the UNSC (see above) has also resulted in competing 'roadmaps' for peace, despite the UN Secretary General's call for coordination of initiatives. The UN action is also hampered on the ground: its mission in Sudan (UNITAMS) withdrew in February 2024, and disagreement has emerged between Sudanese civil society organisations regarding the UN envoy, Ramtane Lamamra, with some in support and others accusing him of being too close to the SAF.

The US and Saudi-Arabia-led '**Jeddah process**' resulted in commitments in May and November 2023 by both the SAF and the RSF to protect civilians, to allow humanitarian access, and to temporarily cease fire. However, these commitments were not upheld. The US and Saudi Arabia also convened peace talks in Geneva, which similarly failed, notably due to SAF demand that the RSF withdraw from territories they had captured since April 2023.

In March 2024, negotiations mediated by **Libya and Türkiye** collapsed after the SAF rejected a proposal for a Ramadan truce supported by the UNSC (with one abstention – Russia) unless the RSF withdrew from civilian sites. This also coincided with the SAF's successful offensive on Khartoum, backed by Iranian drones.

In April 2025, the **London Conference on Sudan** gathered international and regional players, but not the warring parties, and failed to agree on a common position, allegedly due to competing interests, notably between the Arab states backing different sides.

The **African Union**'s (AU) roadmap for the resolution of the conflict in Sudan, supported by most regional and international stakeholders, including the EU, has shown slow progress. While the AU welcomed the SAF's appointment of a civilian prime minister in May 2025, as a step toward inclusive governance, it reaffirmed its commitment to Sudan's territorial integrity and condemned the establishment by the RSF of a parallel government on 26 July 2025. The East-African Intergovernmental Authority on Development (**IGAD**) also drafted a roadmap, which was accepted by the RSF, but rejected by the SAF.

A meeting between **Egypt, Saudi Arabia, the UAE and the US** (**the 'Quad'**) set for 30 July 2025, was postponed notably due to strong disagreement between Egypt and the UAE over the composition of the future government and the balance of powers between civilians and the military. On **12 September 2025**, the Quad reached a compromise and succeeded in agreeing on a **roadmap for peace**, including a three-month humanitarian truce expected to lead to a permanent ceasefire, and the launch of

a political process within nine months, to allow the Sudanese to appoint a transitional civilian-led government, independent of both the SAF and RSF. The Quad declaration also calls on all external players to end their support for either side. The AU and IGAD welcomed this roadmap and committed to consult Sudanese civilian groups, in partnership with the UN, EU, and the League of Arab States, to facilitate an inclusive Sudanese-led political dialogue and transition. While this roadmap represents a diplomatic breakthrough, its implementation remains challenging: the SAF has rejected it, while the RSF has only partially endorsed it.

Experts highlight that the success of any roadmap will depend on coordinated and sustained international pressure.

EU response

Humanitarian action and other assistance

The EU allocated €260 million in 2024 and €269 million in 2025 (as of 19 June 2025) to Sudan and the neighbouring countries affected by the humanitarian crisis caused by the conflict. Priorities for EU humanitarian aid include food assistance, healthcare, water and sanitation, shelter, education, and protection services and support for displaced populations in Chad, South Sudan, Ethiopia, and the Central African Republic. The EU together with its Member States pledged €522 million in aid for 2025. They also activated the ReliefEU emergency response tool to transport nearly 1 000 tonnes of humanitarian goods to Port Sudan by air and other means.

In addition to life-saving assistance, the EU has consistently advocated for the respect of international humanitarian law. In the International Humanitarian Conference for Sudan and neighbouring countries (Paris, 15 April 2024), the Humanitarian Senior Officials meetings on Sudan (Brussels, 13 March 2025) and other fora, the EU called for unhindered humanitarian access and the protection of civilians, including aid workers.

Beyond humanitarian support, the EU has put the cooperation agreement with Sudan (Multi-annual Indicative Programme, MIP) on hold since October 2021. However, it has kept funding programmes 'to address the essential needs of vulnerable groups displaced by the armed conflict in Sudan, with a strong focus on children and young people, women and girls, as well as persons with disability' in coordination with UN agencies, NGOs and the local administration. The EU has long contributed to the protection of IDPs and refugees in Sudan, and to Sudan's migration management in tackling smugglers, safeguarding victims and facilitating their voluntary return and successful reintegration into their countries of origin. In 2017, the EU denied (in an answer to a Parliamentary question) that the RSF were direct or indirect beneficiaries of EU funds – a concern raised as they were at the time deployed near the Libyan border and tasked by Khartoum with stopping migrants on their route to Libya.

Sanctions

To pressure the warring parties to cease fighting and enter into negotiations for a peaceful solution, the EU prohibits the provision of arms or military services to all parties in the conflict and has imposed sanctions on individuals, such as some RSF and SAF leaders (travel bans, asset freezes) – however not on Hemedti or Al-Burhan – and on entities such as mining or trading companies (asset freezes). Exemptions and derogations are possible, particularly to ensure the delivery of humanitarian aid.

Diplomatic initiatives

In several declarations, notably the 11 April 2025 statement by the High Representative (HR), the joint statement of 28 October 2025 by the HR and the Commissioner for Humanitarian Aid and Crisis Management, and the 20 October 2025 Council conclusions, the EU condemns conflict-related sexual violence and attacks on civilians, atrocities and abuses committed by both parties. It urges the parties to the conflict to cease hostilities, enable lasting ceasefires, and work towards a lasting peaceful solution. It also calls on foreign powers to halt all kind of external support.

The EU calls for a transparent and inclusive return to a civilian-led government, respecting Sudan's sovereignty and territorial integrity. It has expressed support for the UN Fact-Finding Mission and the ICC investigations, and international mediation efforts. The EU co-chaired the April 2025 **London Conference** alongside the AU, France, Germany and the United Kingdom (UK), and chaired the **Fourth Consultative Meeting** on peace initiatives coordination in June 2025, bringing together representatives from the IGAD, the Arab League, the AU, the UN and the 'Quad'. On 24 September 2025, on the margins of the 80th UN General Assembly, the EU co-chaired – alongside the AU, France, Germany and the UK – a **ministerial meeting** with representatives of the IGAD, the Arab League, the UN, the 'Quad' members, Denmark, Canada, Chad, Djibouti, Ethiopia, Kenya, Libya, Norway, Qatar, South Sudan, Switzerland, Türkiye and Uganda. They welcomed the Quad roadmap agreement of 12 September 2025, expressed support for the AU and IGAD's efforts to coordinate initiatives towards a ceasefire; condemned external military involvement; and called for the respect of international humanitarian law and specifically for a humanitarian pause in El Fasher.

The EU has so far condemned the RSF and the SAF equally. The creation of a parallel government by RSF allies – condemned by the EU – and the RSF's seizure of El Fasher through means amounting to war crimes might trigger a shift in the EU approach. Some Member States, such as Italy and the Netherlands, reportedly advocate for re-engagement with the UN-recognised civilian-led transitional government linked to the SAF, in order to relaunch the transitional process to democracy, and to lessen Russian and Iranian influence. The EU Special Representative for the Horn of Africa, Annette Weber, and the EU Ambassador to Sudan, Wolfram Vetter, might have to square these calls for pragmatism with the EU's stance on human rights, accountability, and the rule of law. There are notably concerns that the warring parties could use cooperation on curbing migration as leverage for funding and political legitimacy.

European Parliament's position

Since the outbreak of the conflict, the European Parliament has debated the humanitarian crisis, human rights abuses and the use of rape as a weapon of war. It adopted a resolution on 13 March 2025, calling for an immediate end to hostilities and a negotiated solution. This resolution urges all warring parties to respect international humanitarian law; demands full humanitarian access and an increase in EU funding to help those affected, especially survivors of gender-based and sexual violence. It condemns the recruitment of child soldiers, the attacks on civilians and widespread sexual violence, urging that those responsible be held accountable.

Parliament also calls on the Council to impose further sanctions, notably on Hemedti, the RSF leader. It urges the EU and the Council to act against those violating the UN arms embargo on Darfur and to support expanding the embargo to the whole of Sudan.

The Parliament asks the EU and its Member States to support the ICC investigation into war crimes and genocide in Darfur, as well as the UN Fact-Finding Mission on Sudan, and it asks international and regional organisations to deploy a mission to protect civilians, monitor human rights, and investigate sexual violence.

Parliament's Committees on Development (DEVE) and Human Rights (DROI) have invited the UN Fact-Finding Mission, the World Food Programme, and 2007 Sakharov Prize laureate and Sudanese lawyer, Salih Mahmoud Osman, to a hearing on 11 November 2025.

Further reading

Sudan: Security Situation, EU Agency for Asylum, 11 February 2025.

Two years of war: conflict and displacement in Sudan, European Commission's Joint Research Centre, 1 October 2025.

Pichon, E. and Karhilo, J., Sudan: A transition under pressure, EPRS, European Parliament, 2020.

Acknowledgements

Perplexity.ai and Consensus.app were used to broaden the range of sources available to the author. Any AI-assisted content in this text has been reviewed by the author.

Endnotes

[1] Sudan ranks 122th out of 138 economies in the Normandy Index, denoting a very low resilience to threats to peace.

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Contact

E-mail: eprs@ep.europa.eu

Intranet: https://eprs.in.ep.europa.eu/

Internet: https://www.europarl.europa.eu/thinktank

Blog: https://epthinktank.eu